Complex Vectors and Matrices

Last modified: 2026-10-12 20:16:54 (PDT)

Complex vectors and matrices

Definition 0.1 (Complex vectors and matrices)**.** A **complex vector** of length p is a column vector whose entries are complex numbers; the set of all of them is denoted $\mathbb{C}^p$. A **complex matrix** of size $m \times n$ is a matrix with complex entries; the set of all of them is denoted $\mathbb{C}^{m \times n}$.
The **complex conjugate** of a complex vector or matrix takes the complex conjugate of each entry: $(\overline{\mathbf{A}})_{jk} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \overline{a_{jk}}$.

Example 0.1 (A complex vector and its conjugate)**.**

$$\underset{3\times 1}{\tilde{z}} = \begin{bmatrix} 1+i \\ 2 \\ -3\,i \end{bmatrix} \in \mathbb{C}^3, \qquad \underset{3\times 1}{\overline{\tilde{z}}} = \begin{bmatrix} 1-i \\ 2 \\ 3\,i \end{bmatrix}.$$

The real entry 2 is its own conjugate. Every real vector is also a complex vector, since each real number a is the complex number $a + 0\,i$, so $\mathbb{R}^p$ is a subset of $\mathbb{C}^p$.

Definition 0.2 (Conjugate transpose (Hermitian adjoint, Hermitian conjugate, transjugate))**.** The **conjugate transpose** (also called the **Hermitian adjoint**, **Hermitian conjugate**, or **transjugate**) of an $m \times n$ complex matrix $\mathbf{A}$ is the $n \times m$ matrix $\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}$ obtained by transposing $\mathbf{A}$ and then taking the complex conjugate of each entry:

$$(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})_{jk} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \overline{a_{kj}} \quad \text{for } j \in \{1, \ldots, n\},\ k \in \{1, \ldots, m\}.$$

The conjugate transpose of a column vector $\tilde{z} \in \mathbb{C}^p$ is the $1 \times p$ row vector $\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}} = [\overline{z_1},\ \ldots,\ \overline{z_p}]$.

Remark 0.1 (Notation for the conjugate transpose). The operation is denoted variously across mathematics and physics: $\mathbf{A}^*$ in pure mathematics (Axler (2024, Definition 7.7, p. 231)), $\mathbf{A}^\dagger$ ("A-dagger") in physics and quantum mechanics, and $\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H}$ in engineering, numerical linear algebra, and statistics. These notes write $\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H}$ because * is reserved for optimal points (as in $\tilde{x}^*$) and † frequently denotes the Moore-Penrose pseudoinverse in the broader literature.
The Hermitian adjoint matrix should not be confused with the classical *adjugate matrix* (the transpose of the matrix of cofactors), which older texts occasionally referred to as the "adjoint."

Example 0.2 (The conjugate transpose of a 2×3 matrix)**.** For

$$\underset{\smile}{\mathbf{A}}_{2\times 3} = \begin{bmatrix} 1+i & 2 & 0 \\ -i & 3-2\,i & 4 \end{bmatrix},$$

transposing gives a 3×2 matrix, and conjugating each of its entries gives

$$\underset{\smile}{\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H}}_{3\times 2} = \begin{bmatrix} 1-i & i \\ 2 & 3+2\,i \\ 0 & 4 \end{bmatrix}.$$

For instance,

$$\begin{aligned} (\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H})_{12} &= \overline{a_{21}} \\ &= \overline{-i} \\ &= i. \end{aligned}$$

The transpose alone would have $-i$ in that position, so for a matrix with an entry that is not real, $\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H}$ and $\mathbf{A}^\top$ differ. For a real matrix, conjugating changes nothing, so $\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H} = \mathbf{A}^\top$.

Theorem 0.1 (Properties of the Hermitian adjoint)**.** *Let* $\mathbf{A}$ *and* $\mathbf{B}$ *be complex matrices of compatible dimensions, and let* $c \in \mathbb{C}$ *be a scalar. The Hermitian adjoint (Definition 0.2) satisfies:*

1. ***Involution****:*
$$(\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H})^\mathsf{H} = \mathbf{A}$$
2. ***Additivity****:*
$$(\mathbf{A} + \mathbf{B})^\mathsf{H} = \mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H} + \mathbf{B}^\mathsf{H}$$
3. ***Conjugate-homogeneity****:*
$$(c\,\mathbf{A})^\mathsf{H} = \overline{c}\,\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H}$$
4. ***Reversal of products****:*
$$(\mathbf{AB})^\mathsf{H} = \mathbf{B}^\mathsf{H}\mathbf{A}^\mathsf{H}$$

If $\mathbf{A}$ *is invertible, then* $\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}$ *is also invertible, and*

$$(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})^{-1} = (\mathbf{A}^{-1})^{\mathsf{H}}.$$

Proof

Proof. Properties 1-3 follow directly from entrywise conjugation and transposition:

- For involution:

$$\begin{aligned}[(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})^{\mathsf{H}}]_{jk} &= \overline{(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})_{kj}} \\ &= \overline{\overline{a_{jk}}} \\ &= a_{jk}.\end{aligned}$$

- For additivity:

$$\begin{aligned}[(\mathbf{A}+\mathbf{B})^{\mathsf{H}}]_{jk} &= \overline{(\mathbf{A}+\mathbf{B})_{kj}} \\ &= \overline{a_{kj} + b_{kj}} \\ &= \overline{a_{kj}} + \overline{b_{kj}} \\ &= (\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})_{jk} + (\mathbf{B}^{\mathsf{H}})_{jk}.\end{aligned}$$

- For conjugate-homogeneity:

$$\begin{aligned}[(c\,\mathbf{A})^{\mathsf{H}}]_{jk} &= \overline{(c\,\mathbf{A})_{kj}} \\ &= \overline{c\,a_{kj}} \\ &= \overline{c}\,\overline{a_{kj}} \\ &= \overline{c}\,(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})_{jk}.\end{aligned}$$

  Unlike the real transpose where $(c\,\mathbf{A})^{\top} = c\,\mathbf{A}^{\top}$, scaling conjugates the scalar.

For property 4 (reversal of products), let $\mathbf{A}$ be an $m \times k$ matrix and $\mathbf{B}$ a $k \times n$ matrix. Entry (i, j) of the product's Hermitian adjoint (for $i \in \{1, \dots, n\}$ and $j \in \{1, \dots, m\}$) is:

$$
\begin{aligned}
[(\mathbf{AB})^{\mathsf{H}}]_{ij} &= \overline{(\mathbf{AB})_{ji}} && \text{(Definition 0.2)} \\
&= \overline{\sum_{s=1}^{k} a_{js}\, b_{si}} && \text{(definition of matrix multiplication)} \\
&= \sum_{s=1}^{k} \overline{a_{js}}\, \overline{b_{si}} && \text{(conjugate of sums and products)} \\
&= \sum_{s=1}^{k} \overline{b_{si}}\, \overline{a_{js}} && \text{(complex multiplication is commutative)} \\
&= \sum_{s=1}^{k} (\mathbf{B}^{\mathsf{H}})_{is}\, (\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})_{sj} && \text{(Definition 0.2)} \\
&= (\mathbf{B}^{\mathsf{H}}\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})_{ij} && \text{(definition of matrix multiplication).}
\end{aligned}
$$

For the inverse, applying property 4 to $\mathbf{A}\mathbf{A}^{-1} = \mathbf{I}$ gives:

$$
\begin{aligned}
(\mathbf{A}^{-1})^{\mathsf{H}}\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} &= (\mathbf{A}\mathbf{A}^{-1})^{\mathsf{H}} \\
&= \mathbf{I}^{\mathsf{H}} \\
&= \mathbf{I},
\end{aligned}
$$

so $(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})^{-1} = (\mathbf{A}^{-1})^{\mathsf{H}}$. □

Theorem 0.2 (The adjoint property for inner products)**.** *Let* $\mathbf{A}$ *be an* $m \times n$ *complex matrix. Under the standard inner product on complex Euclidean space,* $\langle \tilde{u}, \tilde{v} \rangle \overset{def}{=} \tilde{u}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{v}$*,*

$$
\langle \mathbf{A}\tilde{u}, \tilde{v} \rangle = \langle \tilde{u}, \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{v} \rangle \quad \textit{for all } \tilde{u} \in \mathbb{C}^n \textit{ and } \tilde{v} \in \mathbb{C}^m.
$$

Proof

Proof. By the definition of the standard complex inner product and the product rule for the Hermitian adjoint (Theorem 0.1):

$$
\begin{aligned}
\langle \mathbf{A}\tilde{u}, \tilde{v} \rangle &= (\mathbf{A}\tilde{u})^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{v} && \text{(definition of standard inner product)} \\
&= (\tilde{u}^{\mathsf{H}}\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})\tilde{v} && \text{(Theorem 0.1, reversal of products)} \\
&= \tilde{u}^{\mathsf{H}}(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{v}) && \text{(associativity of matrix multiplication)} \\
&= \langle \tilde{u}, \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{v} \rangle && \text{(definition of standard inner product).}
\end{aligned}
$$

□

Remark 0.2 (Where the name "adjoint" comes from). This identity is the origin of the name **adjoint**: in functional analysis and operator theory, the *adjoint* of a linear map

$T : V \to W$ between inner product spaces is defined as the unique operator $T^* : W \to V$ satisfying $\langle T\tilde{u}, \tilde{v}\rangle = \langle \tilde{u}, T^*\tilde{v}\rangle$ (Axler (2024, Definition 7.1, p. 226)). When V and W are finite-dimensional spaces equipped with their standard orthonormal bases, the matrix representing the adjoint operator T^* is precisely the Hermitian adjoint matrix $\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}$ (Axler (2024, Proposition 7.9, p. 231)).

Theorem 0.3 ($\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{z}$ is a sum of squared absolute values)**.** *For every $\tilde{z} \in \mathbb{C}^p$,*

$$\underbrace{\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}}}_{1\times p}\ \underbrace{\tilde{z}}_{p\times 1} = \sum_{j=1}^{p} |z_j|^2,$$

which is a nonnegative real number, and is 0 only when $\tilde{z} = \tilde{0}_{p\times 1}$.

Proof

Proof. The last step uses the identity for a complex number times its conjugate.

$$\begin{aligned}
\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{z} &= \sum_{j=1}^{p} \overline{z_j}\, z_j && \text{(Definition 0.2, and the row-times-column product)} \\
&= \sum_{j=1}^{p} z_j\, \overline{z_j} && \text{(complex multiplication is commutative)} \\
&= \sum_{j=1}^{p} |z_j|^2 && \text{(a number times its conjugate)}
\end{aligned}$$

By the definition of the absolute value, each $|z_j|^2 = (\operatorname{Re} z_j)^2 + (\operatorname{Im} z_j)^2$ is a nonnegative real number, so their sum is too. A sum of nonnegative numbers is 0 only when every term is 0, and $|z_j|^2 = 0$ only when

$$\begin{aligned}
\operatorname{Re} z_j &= \operatorname{Im} z_j \\
&= 0,
\end{aligned}$$

that is, when $z_j = 0$. □

Example 0.3 (Computing $\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}}\tilde{z}$)**.** Let $\tilde{z} = (1 + i, 2)^{\top}$. By Theorem 0.3,

$$\begin{aligned}
\underbrace{\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}}}_{1\times 2}\ \underbrace{\tilde{z}}_{2\times 1} &= |1+i|^2 + |2|^2 && \text{(Theorem 0.3)} \\
&= (1^2+1^2) + (2^2+0^2) && \text{(definition of the absolute value, squared)} \\
&= 2+4 && \text{(add inside each group)} \\
&= 6 && \text{(add)}
\end{aligned}$$

Multiplying out directly gives the same number: $\overline{2}\cdot 2 = 4$, and

$$\begin{aligned}
\overline{(1+i)}\,(1+i) &= (1-i)(1+i) && \text{(conjugate)} \\
&= 1+i-i-i^2 && \text{(distribute)} \\
&= 1-i^2 && \text{(cancel } i\text{)} \\
&= 2 && (i^2=-1)
\end{aligned}$$

Example 0.4 (Why complex vectors use the conjugate transpose)**.** For a real vector $\tilde{x}$, $\tilde{x}^\top \tilde{x} = \sum_{j=1}^{p} x_j^2$ is 0 only when $\tilde{x}$ is the zero vector. The same formula fails for complex vectors. Let $\tilde{z} = (1, i)^\top$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}
\underbrace{\tilde{z}^{\top}}_{1\times 2}\ \underbrace{\tilde{z}}_{2\times 1} &= 1\cdot 1 + i\cdot i && \text{(multiply entry by entry and add)} \\
&= 1+i^2 && \text{(multiply)} \\
&= 0 && (i^2=-1)
\end{aligned}$$

although $\tilde{z} \neq \tilde{0}_{2\times 1}$. Using the conjugate transpose instead,

$$\begin{aligned}
\underbrace{\tilde{z}^{\mathsf{H}}}_{1\times 2}\ \underbrace{\tilde{z}}_{2\times 1} &= \overline{1}\cdot 1 + \overline{i}\cdot i && \text{(Definition 0.2)} \\
&= 1 + (-i)\cdot i && \text{(conjugate each entry)} \\
&= 1-i^2 && \text{(multiply)} \\
&= 2 && (i^2=-1)
\end{aligned}$$

which is positive, as Theorem 0.3 guarantees.

Definition 0.3 (Hermitian matrix (self-adjoint matrix))**.** A square complex matrix $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{C}^{n\times n}$ is **Hermitian** (or **self-adjoint**) if it equals its conjugate transpose (Definition 0.2):

$$\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = \mathbf{A}.$$

Remark 0.3 (Why "self-adjoint")*.* The term *self-adjoint* comes directly from Theorem 0.2: when $\mathbf{A}$ is Hermitian, $\langle \mathbf{A}\tilde{u}, \tilde{v}\rangle = \langle \tilde{u}, \mathbf{A}\tilde{v}\rangle$ for all $\tilde{u}, \tilde{v} \in \mathbb{C}^n$. The linear operator moves across the inner product without change.

Example 0.5 (A Hermitian matrix)**.**

$$\underbrace{\mathbf{A}}_{2\times 2} = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1-i \\ 1+i & 3 \end{bmatrix}$$

is Hermitian: transposing swaps the off-diagonal entries, and conjugating turns $1+i$ back into $1-i$ and $1-i$ back into $1+i$, so $\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = \mathbf{A}$. The diagonal entries of a Hermitian matrix must be real, because $a_{jj} = \overline{a_{jj}}$, and only a real number is its own conjugate: if $a + b\,i = a - b\,i$, then the imaginary parts give $b = -b$, so $b = 0$.
Every real symmetric matrix is Hermitian, because for a real matrix $\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = \mathbf{A}^{\top}$.

Example 0.6 (A symmetric complex matrix that is not Hermitian)**.**

$$\underbrace{\mathbf{B}}_{2\times 2} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & i \\ i & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

is symmetric, $\mathbf{B}^{\top} = \mathbf{B}$, but it is not Hermitian:

$$\underbrace{\mathbf{B}^{\mathsf{H}}}_{2\times 2} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & -i \\ -i & 0 \end{bmatrix} \neq \mathbf{B}.$$

Definition 0.4 (Skew-Hermitian matrix (anti-Hermitian matrix))**.** A square complex matrix $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{C}^{n\times n}$ is **skew-Hermitian** (or **anti-Hermitian**) if it equals the negative of its conjugate transpose (Definition 0.2):

$$\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = -\mathbf{A}.$$

Remark 0.4 (The diagonal of a skew-Hermitian matrix)*.* Every entry of a skew-Hermitian matrix satisfies $a_{jk} = -\overline{a_{kj}}$. In particular, its diagonal entries satisfy $a_{jj} = -\overline{a_{jj}}$, which means

$$\begin{aligned} a_{jj} + \overline{a_{jj}} &= 2\,\mathrm{Re}(a_{jj}) \\ &= 0. \end{aligned}$$

Therefore, every diagonal entry of a skew-Hermitian matrix must be purely imaginary (or zero). For example, $a_{jj} = 3\,i$ works, since

$$\begin{aligned} -\overline{3\,i} &= -(-3\,i) \\ &= 3\,i, \end{aligned}$$

but $a_{jj} = 3$ does not, since $-\overline{3} = -3$.

Example 0.7 (A skew-Hermitian matrix)**.** The matrix

$$\mathbf{A} = \begin{bmatrix} 2\,i & 1+i \\ -1+i & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

is skew-Hermitian: transposing and conjugating gives

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} &= \begin{bmatrix} \overline{2\,i} & \overline{-1+i} \\ \overline{1+i} & \overline{0} \end{bmatrix} \\ &= \begin{bmatrix} -2\,i & -1-i \\ 1-i & 0 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= -\mathbf{A}. \end{aligned}$$

Its diagonal entries $2\,i$ and 0 are purely imaginary.

Theorem 0.4 (Hermitian and skew-Hermitian decomposition)**.** *Every square complex matrix* $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{C}^{n\times n}$ *can be uniquely expressed as the sum of a Hermitian matrix* $\mathbf{H}$ *(Definition 0.3) and a skew-Hermitian matrix* $\mathbf{S}$ *(Definition 0.4):*

$$\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{H} + \mathbf{S},$$

where

$$\mathbf{H} = \frac{\mathbf{A} + \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}}{2} \quad \textit{and} \quad \mathbf{S} = \frac{\mathbf{A} - \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}}{2}.$$

Proof

Proof. **Existence**: Define $\mathbf{H} = \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{A} + \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})$ and $\mathbf{S} = \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{A} - \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})$. Their sum is:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{H} + \mathbf{S} &= \frac{\mathbf{A} + \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}}{2} + \frac{\mathbf{A} - \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}}{2} \\ &= \frac{2\mathbf{A}}{2} \\ &= \mathbf{A}. \end{aligned}$$

Applying the properties of the Hermitian adjoint (Theorem 0.1):

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{H}^{\mathsf{H}} &= \left(\frac{\mathbf{A}+\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}}{2}\right)^{\mathsf{H}} \\
&= \frac{\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}+(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})^{\mathsf{H}}}{2} \\
&= \frac{\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}+\mathbf{A}}{2} \\
&= \mathbf{H}, \\
\mathbf{S}^{\mathsf{H}} &= \left(\frac{\mathbf{A}-\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}}{2}\right)^{\mathsf{H}} \\
&= \frac{\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}-(\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}})^{\mathsf{H}}}{2} \\
&= \frac{\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}-\mathbf{A}}{2} \\
&= -\mathbf{S}.
\end{aligned}
$$

Thus $\mathbf{H}$ is Hermitian and $\mathbf{S}$ is skew-Hermitian.
Uniqueness: Suppose $\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{H}' + \mathbf{S}'$ with $(\mathbf{H}')^{\mathsf{H}} = \mathbf{H}'$ and $(\mathbf{S}')^{\mathsf{H}} = -\mathbf{S}'$. Taking the Hermitian adjoint of both sides yields:

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} &= (\mathbf{H}'+\mathbf{S}')^{\mathsf{H}} \\
&= (\mathbf{H}')^{\mathsf{H}} + (\mathbf{S}')^{\mathsf{H}} \\
&= \mathbf{H}' - \mathbf{S}'.
\end{aligned}
$$

Adding $\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{H}' + \mathbf{S}'$ and $\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = \mathbf{H}' - \mathbf{S}'$ gives $\mathbf{A} + \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = 2\mathbf{H}'$, so

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{H}' &= \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{A}+\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}) \\
&= \mathbf{H}.
\end{aligned}
$$

Subtracting the two equations gives $\mathbf{A} - \mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}} = 2\mathbf{S}'$, so

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{S}' &= \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{A}-\mathbf{A}^{\mathsf{H}}) \\
&= \mathbf{S}.
\end{aligned}
$$

□

Axler, Sheldon. 2024. *Linear Algebra Done Right*. 4th ed. Undergraduate Texts in Mathematics. Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-41026-0.